never allowed security guards or the police to control the crowds, and, remarkably, the crowd self-regulated.

Meanwhile, I stood waiting near Neyyattinkara, with Vishnunadh by my side, who was there to ease my entry into the Yatra. I began to witness the meticulous organization required for an undertaking of this magnitude. As we waited, announcement Jeeps were already conducting pilots, and security personnel held briefings. People had risen early, lining the roadsides to catch a glimpse of the man. A resident, recognizing our presence, offered to get us some tea. We gratefully accepted, and his wife soon arrived with tea glasses on a plate. This gesture, I would later learn, was a common occurrence throughout the Yatra, with people voluntarily serving tea and snacks to the yatris, which was also a testament to the '*athithi devo bhava*' attitude of Keralites.

The anticipation in the air grew and the rhythmic sound of a thousand determined footsteps reverberated. Amid this throng was Rahul, clad in a white T-shirt and dark pants, leading the procession. We shook hands, and what followed was a candid exchange, well documented by Bharat Jodo's social media handles and various media outlets. I couldn't help but delve into the conversation with journalistic curiosity, but the response I received was far from the usual political rhetoric. It was open, incisive and direct, and Rahul was sharing his thoughts even while other Congress leaders listened.

Sridhar R. (SR): Rahul, is this walk about India or is it about the Congress?

Rahul Gandhi (RG): The Congress, the way I see it, is a conversation. The conversation in the country is dead. This walk is about reigniting that conversation.

SR: But this conversation can't be just about you alone. It needs to involve everyone in your party. I'm reminded of the NYAY scheme, which, to me, had the potential to be a game-changer in the 2019 elections. However, only you were seen campaigning across the country for this Universal Basic